

Victor of Vita 484

Historia II.41–44 — Eugenius of Carthage: the faith is the whole world's cause; the Roman church the head of all the churches (A.D. 484; CSEL 7, pp. 40–42)

[[p. 40]] It was debated what should be done. The impending calamity found no remedy, except that a reasoned representation should be submitted by holy Eugenius — in the hope that the barbarian's heart might be softened — drawn up in the following terms:

[41] “As often as the cause of the soul, or of eternal life, or of the Christian faith is treated, it is necessary — fearlessly, as the royal foresight has promised — that what is fitting be submitted. Recently the royal power deigned to admonish my littleness through the notary Uitarit, who, for the sake of religion and faith, recited to us his [the king's] command in the church, in the presence of the clergy and people. From its tenor we learned that the royal command had likewise gone forth to all my fellow-bishops, that on an appointed day there should be a coming-together for a disputation on the faith; and we submitted that we had received this reverently. To the aforesaid notary my humility submitted that [the bishops] of all the regions beyond the sea also, who are partakers with us in one religion and communion, ought to take cognizance [of it], since everywhere all are subject to his rule — especially because it is the cause of the whole world, and not peculiar [42] to the African provinces alone. And because I promised in a second reply that I would present a submission, I deservedly and suppliantly beg your magnificence that you would deign to convey my aforesaid representation to the ears of the lord and most clement king, so that his clemency may graciously acknowledge that we in no way decline or flee the disputation of the law with the help of God, but that we ought not to take up the pleading of our faith without the assent of the whole [Church]. This we beg that he may deign to grant with such benignity and [[p. 41]] justice as befits his wisdom. Given by Eugenius, bishop of the catholic church of Carthage.”

[43] (II, 15) But when this representation was being presented by blessed Eugenius, that man — who had already conceived grief — was being driven to bring forth iniquity more grievously; and so he seems to have sent word to the holy man, bishop Eugenius, through Obadus, the overseer of his kingdom: “Subject to me the whole world, that the entire world may be brought under my power, and I will do, O Eugenius, what you say.” To which blessed Eugenius replied as best he could: “What has no reason,” he said, “ought not to be said: this is just as if it were said to a man that he should be carried through the air and fly about, which is not the custom of human nature. For what I said was this: if the royal power desires to know our faith, which is one and true, let him send to his friends; I too will write to my brethren, that my fellow-bishops may come who, together with us, may be able to demonstrate to you our common faith — and especially the Roman church, which is the head of all the churches.” To this Obadus [said]: “So then, are you and my lord the king equals?” Bishop Eugenius said: “I am not the king's equal; but what I said was: if he desires to know the true faith, let him write to his friends, that

they may direct our catholic bishops hither, and I will write to my fellow-bishops, since the cause of the whole catholic [body] is one.” This Eugenius did, not because there were lacking in Africa men who might refute the objections of the adversaries, but so that those men might come who, being strangers to their [the Vandals’] dominion, would have greater confidence of liberty [[p. 42]] and would likewise announce to all lands and peoples the calumnies of our oppression.

Liber fidei catholicae, close (Historia II.100–101) — the faith founded on the fellowship of all the catholic churches in this world (pp. 70–71)

[[p. 70]] [100] (III, 23) Let there be for us, therefore, in accordance with the confession of saving baptism, a whole and entire faith of the Trinity; let there be one devotion of piety; and let us not, after the manner of the gentiles, imagine diversities of powers, nor suspect anything created, as regards deity, within the Trinity. But neither let us be moved by the scandal of the Jews, who deny the Son of God, who do not adore the Spirit; but rather, adoring and magnifying the perfect Trinity, as we say with our mouth in the [sacred] mysteries, so let us hold with our conscience: Holy, holy, holy, Lord God of hosts. Saying “Holy” three times, [[p. 71]] we confess one omnipotence, since there is one religion, one glorification of the Trinity — that we may listen to the apostles, as the Corinthians listened [to them]: The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the communion of the Holy Spirit be with you all. [101] This is our faith, founded upon the evangelical and apostolic traditions and upon the fellowship of all the catholic churches that are in this world, in which [faith] we trust and hope, by the grace of Almighty God, to remain until the end of this life.

Delivered on the twelfth [day] before the Kalends of May [20 April, marg. *a. 484*] by [the hands of] Ianuarius of Zattara [and] Uillaticus of Casae Medianae, bishops of Numidia, [and] Bonifatius of Foratiana and Bonifatius of Gatiana, bishops of Byzacena.